

Practice

Formation Audit

Practice helps the information we take in become a part of who we are and transform our lives.

Our exercise for this session is to take an inventory of all the forces that are currently forming you.

- 01 This is one of the longest exercises in this Course, and we recommend you carve out a quiet time and place to spend ample time in thoughtful reflection and prayer.
- 02 Invite the Spirit of Jesus to come and illuminate your mind, silence the voice of the evil one, and to “give you the Spirit of wisdom and revelation, so that you may know him better,” and that “the eyes of your heart may be enlightened.”*
- 03 Remember to answer *honestly* and *non-judgmentally*. You will likely feel your heart drift toward shame and denial, both of which will sabotage the effectiveness of this exercise.
- 04 Above all, do this exercise *with God*. Slowly and prayerfully, and with your heart at peace.

* Ephesians 1v17-18

Habits — What habits make up your everyday life? Write out your habits.

Morning routine:

Reading, coffee with Susie, workouts (strength & yoga), walking the dogs

Monday - 8 am prayer call (Improving)

Activities of a typical workday:

One on ones, Calls with partners & clients, Proactive work (research, reading, and building decks), Networking

Journaling (performance journaling & exploratory journaling)

Evening routine:

Cooking dinner with Susie, bottle(s) of wine, couch time for TV and catch up, reading before bed

Working on side-projects - always have something cooking

Activities of a typical weekend:

Yoga, church, golf, cigars, yardwork, errands, time with Declan

Family get togethers (mine) occasionally Susie's, chores

Reflection: How do you think your habits are shaping you as a person? (See the two lists on page 37 for a list of possible effects)

I focus on my habits pretty regularly. I struggle with getting the right amount of what I want to do and what I need to do currently.

I focus can overindex on achievement of these items rather than being relational in these times. I often will skip or pass on opportunities to help others

because of my schedule or plans. Self-focused. Goal oriented.

Relationships — What relationships make up most of your life?

Family:

Immediate family (daily), extended family (monthly)

Friends:

Close friends (monthly), acquaintances (quarterly)

Work:

Close friends (daily)

Community:

Weekly for some like church, at least monthly (although almost weekly now with 2 forums) for YPO,

Other:

Reflection: How are these people shaping you as a person? The key questions to ask are: What kind of person do I become when I'm around this person? What do they draw out in me or suppress in me?

People are the foundation of my purpose and build so much of my efforts around them - they make me social and feel connected. They also make me feel important because I'm able to help many of them. I only have a small number of people that truly have a say in my life - can challenge me on my ideas, beliefs, and actions. The broader groups have pushed me to find a more integrated way to approach life.

Stories you believe — What are the “stories” you have come to believe?

What stories do you believe about God? (What is he like/not like? How does he feel toward you?)

This has changed dramatically over the years - I was raised in an environment that made me feel like God was looking for perfection & performance.

Now I understand it's a relationship and he wants to help me achieve the best I can aligning me with His purpose. Like what I want for my kids

I wrestle with feeling God isn't disappointed in me at so many times.

What stories do you believe about yourself? (How does God see you? How do others see you? What kind of person are you? What do you see for your future?)

Fallible and broken - this is the disappointment I mentioned earlier. I tend to be a steady and caring person although I can be pretty vindictive when I feel wronged. Seems like I'm maybe mellowing out as I've gotten older - tired? Flexible?

What stories do you believe about happiness? (What do you think will make you most happy and peaceful? Is it God? Money? Marriage? Success? Vacation?)

I realize that happiness comes from contentment - learning to be grateful AND ENJOY what I have now. Less striving

What stories do you believe about the meaning of life? (What do you think matters most? Perhaps your career? Family? Health? Something else?)

Relationships are the currency of life. It's what we are to spend ours on. It is the treasure we store up in heaven - one day you will see all your treasure

When you walk into the arms of all that you have loved.

Reflection: What are the core stories of my life? Are they forming me as a person?

Struggled early on - nerdy and picked on thru middle school. We were poor (didn't feel it but knew it) and very well cared for and loved. Influences my relationship with achievement and success (stories I tell myself about what my kids have/didn't have growing up).

Successful entrepreneur - 5 so far (more to come) and I seem to know a little bit. I became a people person and love companies of culture.

Good husband - my ex wife called me that (even in the divorce). Susie calls me that. I feel that.

Environment — What are the cultural distinctives of my environment?

City: What is my city like? What is it known for?

13 houses by the time I was done with high school. Never had a “hometown” I could claim. My city is Frisco as much as anything. Definitely DFW is pointed towards the materialistic as a normative. Frisco too - it's a bubble known for successful athletes and business people. High achievement and success.

Nation: What is my nation like? What are its highest cultural values?

Materialistic and prosperous. Self-focused and truth-defining, in our own image.

Generation: What are my generation's values?

Digital algorithm: What are the algorithms feeding me news, information, and social connection like?

X, WSJ, Podcasts (All In, Alistair Begg, HBR), Business Insider, social (sometimes w/Insta, LI, FB thru Susie)

Ethnic and/or socio-economic group: What are the values and cultural norms and expectations of my cultural heritage and socio-economic class?

Rich white guy. High achiever. Providing for family, community, and having a great retirement

Reflection: How am I being formed or deformed by the cultural forces that are “normal” in my city/nation/generation/social media feed, but possibly far from the vision of Jesus?

Experience — What life experiences have most shaped me into who I am today?

Family of origin: What is my family like? What are its highest values? Deepest dysfunctions?

Greatest legacy?

Connection & care. Performance orientation & physicality

Traumatic events: Have I experienced a traumatic event? What story has my body wordlessly learned from that trauma?

Death of Luke - drank heavily in the aftermath. It took me years to get past the feeling of responsibility. Substance abuse and self medicating became normative after this - smoking, drinking, drugs and sex.

Didn't plan to make it to 30 - life fast, die young, and leave a good looking corpse.

Key experiences: What are the key moments on the timeline of my life that have altered the trajectory of my story?

Move to Texas. Makena's birth. Improving interview

Spiritual autobiography: What are the key moments of my spiritual journey thus far?

5 - sitting on steps with my mom. Baptized in Frio River at HEB camp at 12. Makena's birth

Reflection: How have my experiences formed and deformed me over the years? Where do I still need healing? What do I need to never forget and hold on to? What am I still missing?

Tried hard to break familial cycles. Makena relationship is still broken and I have no path forward.

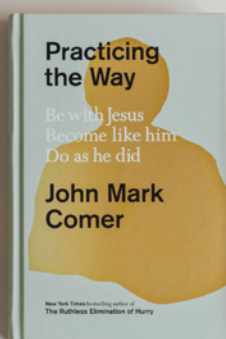
God has been foundational in the path of my family starting with my parents - stay the course with him.

Possible effects of following “the pattern of this world”:

- Stress
- Outrage
- Disconnection
- Debt
- Hurry
- Pride
- Lying
- Laziness
- Anxiety
- Distraction
- Dirty speech
- Alcoholism
- Fear
- Numbness
- Sarcasm
- Addiction
- Insecurity
- Overwhelm
- Put downs
- Substance abuse
- Hypervigilance
- Exhaustion
- Dishonor of authority
- Impulsiveness
- Jealousy
- Discouragement
- Contempt
- Lust
- Anger
- Loneliness
- Careerism
- Pornography
- Irritation
- Isolation
- Overwork
- Racism
- Impatience
- Shame
- Materialism
- Bigotry
- Resentment
- Division
- Discontent

Possible markers of following the Way of God’s Kingdom:

- Love
- Unhurried living
- Equity
- Restfulness
- Joy
- Simplicity of life
- Diversity
- Diligence
- Peace
- Calm
- Trust
- A sense of meaning and purpose
- Patience
- Generosity
- Acceptance
- A clear sense of direction
- Kindness
- Contentment
- Authenticity
- Creativity
- Gentleness
- Freedom
- Honesty
- Growth
- Faithfulness
- Warmth and affection
- Integrity
- Self-control
- Relational connection
- Harmony
- Faith
- Community
- Vulnerability
- Hope
- Sense of belonging
- Compassion



This session’s reading

For this session, we’re reading “Goal #1: Be with Jesus,” in *Practicing the Way* by John Mark Comer, pp. 32-63.